provincial election was the real measure of its political shift. The number of SC candidates remained constant because SC seats are reserved and all parties have to field them anyway. If you take out reserved seats, OBCs accounted for as many as 40 per cent of BJP candidates. Overall, the next highest caste category after OBCs in the BJP's assembly candidate list was SC: eighty-four (20.8 per cent); Brahmins: seventy-five (20.3 per cent), followed by Thakurs: seventy (17.3 per cent).

Table 3.1: BJP Significantly Increased OBC Candidates: Caste Composition of BJP Lok Sabha Candidates in UP, 2004–2019

Caste	*2004*	*2009*	*2014*	*2019*	*2019, Caste %*	*2019*	*Cumulative Caste Categories, 2019*	*% 2019*
Brahmin	18	19	18	18	22.5	General Category	33	41.25
Thakur	16	16	13	13	16.25			
Kayasth		-	-	-				
Bhumihar	1	1	1	1	1.25			
Bania	1	2	3	1	1.25			
Punjabi Khatri	1	2	-	-				
Sikh						Minorities	1	1.25
Muslim	2	1	-	-				
Parsi		-	1	1	1.25			
OBC	**21**	**15**	**26 (2 Yadavs)**	**29 (1 Yadav)**	**36.25**	**Castes that have reservation in govt jobs and education**	46	57.5
Scheduled Castes (SC)	17	15	17	17	21.25			
Did not contest		9	-	-				
Total	80 (contested 77)	80	79	80				

Source: Fieldwork and analysis by Mehta–Singh Social Index. Lok Sabha candidates analysed from ECI data. Figures for 2014 and 2019 include two seats contested by its pre-poll alliance partner Apna Dal (Soneylal).

To put this in perspective, the BJP fielded more OBC candidates (127) in 2017 than SP, the main caste-based OBC party in UP. SP fielded only 100 OBCs, and that too mostly Yadavs, who comprise a small though socially dominant chunk of this group. The BJP also fielded almost as many *SC* candidates (eighty-four) as the main party of the Dalits, BSP (eighty-six). It did field more upper-caste candidates than these parties in percentage terms, but crucially, its combined OBC+SC representation was virtually the